

ODD-TOED UNGULATES

All members of the Perissodactyla are browsers and grazers of plants. They appear to have little in common, but are linked through a series of extinct intermediate forms.

Modern odd-toed ungulate families range from graceful horses to pig-like tapirs and massive rhinoceroses. Unlike the Artiodactyla, they have a relatively simple stomach, and rely on bacteria in the caecum, a pouch-like extension of the large intestine, and colon to digest plant cellulose.

In prehistoric times, odd-toed ungulates were among the most important herbivorous mammals, sometimes becoming the dominant herbivores in grassland and forest ecosystems. For a variety of reasons, including competition with even-toed ungulates, most of these species are now known only from the fossil record.

WEIGHT-BEARING TOES

Odd-toed ungulates rest their weight primarily on the third toe of each foot. Indeed, horses have lost the rest of their toes, and the single remaining digit is protected

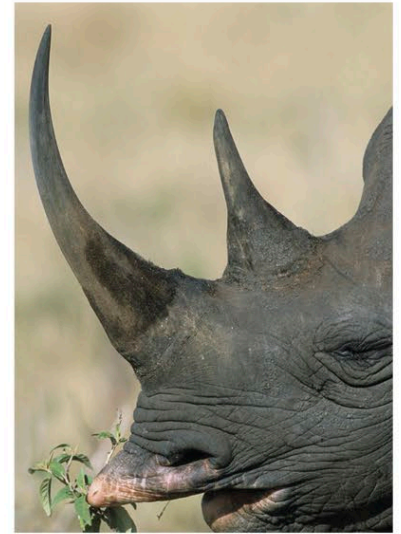
with a well-developed horny hoof. The other two families have retained more toes — three on all four feet in the case of rhinoceroses, and three on the hind legs and four on the front in the case of tapirs.

HORSE POWER

Once distributed across the world, apart from Antarctica and Australasia, extant species in this order are mainly native to Africa and Asia. Only some of the tapir species are found in the Americas, for although the horse family evolved in that region, it had died out by the end of the Pleistocene around 10,000 years ago. The Spanish conquistadors reintroduced the modern domestic horse to the Americas in the 15th century.

Horses have a long history of domestication, especially as transport and pack animals and to provide power for agriculture and forestry. The first equid to be domesticated appears to have been the donkey, some 5,000 years ago, with horses following 4,000 years ago. Today there are over 250 horse breeds worldwide.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	PERISSODACTYLA
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	18



The black rhinoceros is a browser and has a prehensile upper lip, which it uses to grasp twigs and leaves.

RHINOCEROSES

A huge, barrel-shaped body and a large head bearing one or two horns make the five species of the family Rhinocerotidae unmistakable. While their bulk, horns, and protective skin ensure they have few natural enemies, these mostly solitary animals are threatened by hunting and the destruction of their habitat. These herbivores can ferment food in their hindgut, which enables them to eat woody as well as leafy matter.



SUMATRAN RHINOCEROS

Dicerorhinus sumatrensis

This critically endangered species from S.E. Asian forests is the smallest rhinoceros. The smaller of its two horns is usually a mere stub.



BLACK RHINOCEROS

Diceros bicornis

Smaller but more aggressive than the white rhinoceros, this critically endangered animal of sub-Saharan Africa has a prehensile upper lip to draw twigs and leaves into its mouth.

